

Exercise 21: Blind Man Assist

Purpose:

Practice leadership and communication skills through successful planning

Time Required:

10 min

Brief Outline:

- Cadets will line up on one side of an “imaginary mine field” dictated by the Flt/CC (see diagram below).
- Make half of the cadets “blind” by telling them to close their eyes (or make half take off blouses/hats just to identify who is blind).
 - If there are an odd number of cadets, have one cadet be the observer.
- The objective is to get all members of the team across the mine field safely. Safety regulations state that a blind member must always be escorted by two seeing members, one on each side.
 - Additionally, no one may cross the minefield with less than two members and no more than four members.
 - Lastly, no blind members may be left alone (without at least one seeing member) on any side of the mine field.

Directions to Cadets:

- “For today’s group leadership problem your objective is to get your entire team across an active mine field safely to the other side. Half of your team members are blind. There are rules for safety that must be obeyed at all times.
- First, a blind member must be escorted by two seeing members when crossing the minefield.
- Second, if there are any blind members on a side there must be at least one seeing member present (i.e. do not leave blind members alone).
 - Any trip across the mine field must be by minimum of two and a maximum of three persons at one time.
 - Only one group may traverse the mine field at a time (in either direction). You will have 10 min to complete this task. Are there any questions?”

Challenges:

- There are limited resources (seeing people) to make the trips in a logical manner (i.e. 2 seeing members + 1 blind member).
- Advanced planning will need to happen to ensure that no blind team members are left alone and there are enough seeing members to make the trips. This requires seeing members to travel back and forth in pairs to accomplish the mission.

Debrief questions:

1. What was the most difficult challenge you faced?
2. What were some obstacles (obvious and not obvious)?
3. Was the objective easily understood by all?
4. Ask different cadets whether they felt like they knew what was going on at different points during the exercise.
5. Was there a leader? How did you know?
6. Would this have been easier if I had given you 3 min to plan before execution? How would this have changed your approach?

